

D578

Capstone in Psychology

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A student who coaches youth soccer every weekend wants her capstone to address teen mental health. Her advisor says the scope is too broad. Which revised problem statement is best?

- A. Youth coaches should be kinder to their players.
- B. Mental health is a crisis for every young person everywhere.
- C. Teen mental health should be improved with a mindfulness app.
- D. Reported anxiety among ninth graders at two rural high schools in one county has risen for three years, and neither school offers a coping-skills program.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A student proposing an intervention for loneliness in older adults finds four sources: a meta-analysis of 30 randomized trials, a single randomized trial from a prestigious university, a blog by a well-known therapist with 2 million followers, and an expert panel's opinion. Which gives the strongest evidence that the intervention works?

- A. The meta-analysis of 30 randomized trials.
- B. The expert panel's opinion.
- C. The therapist's blog, because it reaches the most people.
- D. The single trial from the prestigious university.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which source ranks lowest on the evidence hierarchy for judging whether a therapy works?

- A. An editorial giving an expert's opinion.
- B. A large cohort study.
- C. A systematic review of randomized trials.
- D. A randomized controlled trial.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

For her literature review, a student finds a well-written article, published last month, on the website of a company that sells a stress-relief supplement. The article cites five studies and concludes the supplement works. How should she treat it?

- A. As reliable, because it cites five studies.
- B. She should reject every source that is not a journal article.
- C. As a biased source; she should find peer-reviewed studies to check the claim.
- D. As reliable, because it was published last month.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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5.

A survey of 1,200 college students, collected online over the spring semester, finds that students who use the campus gym more report lower depression scores ($r = -.35$). A student proposes requiring all students to use the gym to reduce depression. What is the main problem with this proposal?

- A. Online data collection makes the results invalid.
- B. Correlation cannot show gym use causes lower depression; less-depressed students may simply go more, or a third factor may drive both.
- C. A negative correlation means gym use increases depression.
- D. The sample of 1,200 is too small to find anything.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which design could test whether exercise causes lower depression in college students?

- A. Repeat the survey with 10,000 students.
- B. Add more variables to the correlation analysis.
- C. Interview frequent gym users about how they feel.
- D. Randomly assign students to an exercise program or a waitlist, then compare depression scores.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ___	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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7.

A student with a background in marketing is designing a strategy to reduce stigma about counseling among first-generation immigrant families in one city neighborhood. Which step best reflects cultural responsiveness?

- A. Assume all immigrant families share the same beliefs about counseling.
- B. Use a program that worked in a suburban population without changes.
- C. Involve community members and leaders in shaping the strategy and adapt materials to their languages and values.
- D. Launch a polished ad campaign based on her marketing experience alone.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A student plans to pilot a peer-support text line for grieving college students, funded by a \$500 grant from a campus club. She intends to save the messages to measure outcomes. What is the most important ethical step before collecting any data?

- A. Skip consent, because the service only helps people.
- B. Get ethics review and informed consent, and set up protections for the confidentiality of messages.
- C. Spend the grant on advertising so enough students sign up.
- D. Debrief participants after the data are collected instead of asking consent first.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Midway through a pilot, the team sees that the program seems to be increasing distress for some participants. Which ethical principle most directly requires action?

- A. Nonmaleficence: avoid harm, so pause or change the program and offer support.
- B. Justice: make sure every group gets the program equally.
- C. Autonomy: let participants decide on their own with no change by the team.
- D. Keep following the protocol exactly so the data stay clean.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A proposal for a workplace mindfulness program at a 250-employee credit union lists its outcome as improved well-being. Which is the best operational definition of that outcome?

- A. Well-being as each participant chooses to define it.
- B. Change in scores on a validated well-being scale from baseline to eight weeks.
- C. Employees feel better.
- D. The number of employees at the credit union.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A researcher states that social isolation will mean fewer than two in-person contacts per week. What is the main purpose of stating this?

- A. To remove the need for a sample.
- B. To make the variable impossible to criticize.
- C. So others can measure the variable the same way and replicate the study.
- D. To prove that isolation causes depression.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A student's capstone addresses chronic pain and depression among veterans served by a clinic that just opened a new parking garage. Which framing of the strategy is strongest?

- A. Rely on medication alone.
- B. Treat it as a matter of personal willpower.
- C. Find the one factor that always causes both pain and depression.
- D. Combine coordinated medical care, a psychological therapy such as CBT, and peer or family support.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A student ~~who coaches youth soccer every weekend~~ wants her capstone to address teen mental health. Her advisor says the scope is too broad. Which revised problem statement is best?

Target word: best problem statement **Decides:** Specific population, setting, and measurable gap without a built-in solution.

A	Camouflage	Pulls in the coaching detail and states an opinion, not a documented gap.
B	Absolute language	Sweeping and unmeasurable; the scope problem remains.
C	Adjacent category	States a solution, not a problem, and is still broad.
D	Correct	Names population, setting, a measurable trend, and a gap.

2. Answer A Concept 2

A student proposing an intervention for loneliness in older adults finds four sources: a meta-analysis of 30 randomized trials, a single randomized trial ~~from a prestigious university~~, a blog by a well-known therapist ~~with 2 million followers~~, and an expert panel's opinion. Which gives the strongest evidence that the intervention works?

Target word: strongest evidence of effectiveness **Decides:** Study design, not prestige or reach.

A	Correct	Pooled results of many trials sit at the top of the hierarchy.
B	Adjacent category	Expert opinion is the lowest tier for effectiveness questions.
C	Confusion set	Popularity is not evidence.
D	Camouflage	Prestige does not outrank a synthesis of many trials.

3. Answer A Concept 2 · transfer

Which source ranks lowest on the evidence hierarchy for judging whether a therapy works?

Target word: lowest-tier source **Decides:** Opinion without systematic data.

A	Correct	Opinion without systematic data is the lowest level.
B	Confusion set	Observational, but still above opinion.
C	Inverted operation	That is the highest tier, not the lowest.
D	Adjacent category	A single trial is high on the hierarchy.

4. Answer C Concept 3

For her literature review, a student finds a ~~well-written article, published last month,~~ on the website of a company that sells a stress-relief supplement. The article cites five studies and concludes the supplement works. How should she treat it?

Target word: credibility judgment **Decides:** The publisher profits from the conclusion.

A	Dropped element	Ignores the conflict of interest and whether the studies were fairly chosen.
B	Absolute language	Government reports and other gray literature can be credible; judge each on its merits.
C	Correct	A financial conflict of interest undermines credibility.
D	Camouflage	Recency does not remove bias.

5. Answer B Concept 4

A survey of 1,200 college students, ~~collected online over the spring semester~~, finds that students who use the campus gym more report lower depression scores ($r = -.35$). A student proposes requiring all students to use the gym to reduce depression. What is the main problem with this proposal?

Target word: flaw in the reasoning **Decides:** The data are correlational.

A	Camouflage	The collection mode does not decide the causal problem.
B	Correct	Reverse causation and third variables remain open.
C	Inverted operation	Negative means as one rises the other falls.
D	Wrong stem number	1,200 is a large sample; size is not the flaw.

6. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

Which design could test whether exercise causes lower depression in college students?

Target word: design that supports a causal claim **Decides:** Random assignment to conditions.

A	Dropped element	A bigger survey is still correlational.
B	Adjacent category	Controls help but cannot rule out all unmeasured causes.
C	Confusion set	No comparison group, so no causal test.
D	Correct	Random assignment balances other factors so differences can be attributed to exercise.

7. Answer C Concept 5

A student ~~with a background in marketing~~ is designing a strategy to reduce stigma about counseling among first-generation immigrant families in one city neighborhood. Which step best reflects cultural responsiveness?

Target word: culturally responsive step **Decides:** The strategy targets a specific cultural community.

A	Absolute language	Treats a diverse group as uniform.
B	Dropped element	Leaves out cultural adaptation.
C	Correct	Co-design and adaptation fit the strategy to the community.
D	Camouflage	Leans on her background instead of community input.

8. Answer B Concept 6

A student plans to pilot a peer-support text line for grieving college students, ~~funded by a \$500 grant from a campus club~~. She intends to save the messages to measure outcomes. What is the most important ethical step before collecting any data?

Target word: required ethical step **Decides:** Sensitive data from people will be collected.

A	Inverted operation	A helpful aim does not remove the duty to obtain consent.
B	Correct	Participants must agree knowingly and their sensitive data must be protected.
C	Camouflage	Funding use does not address participant protection.
D	Adjacent category	Debriefing supplements consent; it does not replace it.

9. Answer A Concept 6 • transfer

Midway through a pilot, the team sees that the program seems to be increasing distress for some participants. Which ethical principle most directly requires action?

Target word: principle triggered by harm **Decides:** Participants are being harmed.

A	Correct	Do-no-harm overrides the wish to finish data collection.
B	Adjacent category	Fair distribution does not address active harm.
C	Confusion set	Respecting choice matters, but the team still must act to prevent harm.
D	Inverted operation	Puts data ahead of participant welfare.

10. Answer B Concept 7

A proposal for a workplace mindfulness program ~~at a 250-employee credit union~~ lists its outcome as improved well-being. Which is the best operational definition of that outcome?

Target word: best operational definition **Decides:** A specific, reproducible measure.

A	Adjacent category	Personal definitions cannot be compared or reproduced.
B	Correct	Names the instrument and timing, so others can repeat it.
C	Dropped element	No measure is stated.
D	Wrong stem number	Headcount does not measure well-being.

11. Answer C Concept 7 • transfer

A researcher states that social isolation will mean fewer than two in-person contacts per week. What is the main purpose of stating this?

Target word: why operational definitions are written **Decides:** Makes measurement explicit and repeatable.

A	Confusion set	A definition does not replace data collection.
B	Absolute language	Definitions can still be challenged as too narrow or wide.
C	Correct	That is the function of an operational definition.
D	Adjacent category	Definitions support measurement, not causal proof.

12. Answer D Concept 8

A student's capstone addresses chronic pain and depression among veterans served by a clinic ~~that just opened a new parking garage~~. Which framing of the strategy is strongest?

Target word: best framing **Decides:** The issue has medical, psychological, and social parts.

A	Dropped element	Leaves out the psychological and social levels.
B	Confusion set	Reduces a multi-factor issue to character.
C	Absolute language	The model rejects single-cause explanations.
D	Correct	Addresses biological, psychological, and social factors together.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	4	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	A scoped problem statement	A usable problem statement names a specific population, setting, and measurable gap, and does not smuggle in the solution.	Choosing a broad cause ("teen mental health") or stating the fix as the problem.	An advisor says the scope is too broad.
2	The evidence hierarchy	For questions of effectiveness, systematic reviews and meta-analyses of randomized trials outrank single trials, which outrank observational studies, which outrank expert opinion.	Ranking evidence by the author's fame or the institution's prestige.	Several sources of different design for the same question.
3	Source credibility	Judge a source by authority, method, and conflicts of interest; peer-reviewed research is preferred, and sellers of a product are biased sources about it.	Accepting a source because it is recent, polished, or cites studies.	The publisher profits from the conclusion.
4	Correlation is not causation	Correlational data cannot show cause; reverse causation and third variables remain possible. Random assignment is needed to test cause.	Proposing a mandate because two things move together.	A survey correlation followed by a causal recommendation.
5	Diverse perspectives and cultural responsiveness	Effective psychosocial strategies are shaped with the community they serve and adapted to its language and values.	Transplanting a program unchanged or treating a group as uniform.	A proposal for a specific cultural community.
6	Research and practice ethics	Protect participants: informed consent, ethics review, confidentiality, and stopping or changing anything that causes harm (nonmaleficence).	Assuming a helpful purpose excuses skipping consent or continuing despite harm.	Collecting data from people, or signs of harm midway.
7	Operational definitions	An operational definition states exactly how a concept will be measured so others can reproduce it.	Leaving outcomes as vague feelings or letting each person define them.	An abstract outcome such as "well-being" in a proposal.
8	The biopsychosocial model	Psychosocial problems arise from interacting biological, psychological, and social factors, so strong strategies address more than one level.	Blaming a single cause or willpower alone.	A complex issue with medical, emotional, and social elements.

Course scope (public description): The Capstone in Psychology is a culminating experience for the B.S. in Psychology program. In this project-based course, students will apply their skills and psychological expertise obtained through the program to an issue of personal interest. Students will think deeply and use their creative problem-solving skills and understanding of diverse perspectives. Upon completion of the capstone, students will have proposed an evidence-based strategy to address a real-world psychosocial issue. The tasks for this course could be used as artifacts for a professional portfolio. There are no prerequisites for this course.